

Routing Pod: Three-Week Readout

Early observations and stability priorities

Routing is a capable team operating in a fragile model.

My early observation is that the primary constraint is not simply engineering headcount. Effective capacity is being lost through reactive support, concentrated system knowledge, work engineering engineering before it is ready and recurring system issues that continue to require manual intervention.

Reactive Operating Model

Support, incidents and urgent tasks regularly displace planned work and system investment.

Concentrated Knowledge

Critical system context remains concentrated around Vince, limiting team independence and making additional capacity difficult to absorb.

Execution Gaps

Work can reach Engineering before the problem, requirement and dependencies are sufficiently understood to execute confidently.

Recurring System Issues

Manual intervention and unreliable workflows continue generating engineering work that competes with fixing the underlying causes.

Near-term priority: Stabilize how Routing operates and create effective capacity before making larger organizational changes.

Routing SWOT

Strengths

- **Strong Technical Capabilities.** The team has capable engineers and deep system/domain expertise.
- **Leadership Alignment is Emerging.** Engineering and Product leaders increasingly recognize the problems around support, system health, capacity and concentration risk.
- **Team Appetite for Improvement.** Engineers consistently want more space for feature work, system improvements and deeper ownership.
- **Early Changes are Working.** The reroute reset, onboarding work and increased attention to intake are starting to address root causes rather than symptoms.

Weaknesses

- **Knowledge Concentration.** Too much critical context and troubleshooting capability still collapses back to a small number of people, especially Vince.
- **Reactive Support Load.** Support and manual intervention consumes capacity and repeatedly interrupts planned work.
- **Weak Execution Pipeline.** Discovery, refinement and planning do not consistently turn ideas into well-understood, executable work.
- **Onboarding and Documentation Gaps.** New or temporary engineers require significant context before they become effective Routing capacity.
- **Product/Engineering Discover Gaps.** Engineering is often involved while fundamental questions about the problem and expected outcome are still unresolved.

Opportunities

- **Move from SME Dependency to Team Ownership.** Use pairing, secondary ownership, documentation and deliberate knowledge transfer to distribute critical context.
- **Turn Support into System Improvement.** Improve intake while connecting recurring support patterns to root-cause engineering work.
- **Create a Real Execution Path.** Strengthen Product/Engineering discovery, work readiness, refinement and prioritization.
- **Increase Senior Engineering Leverage.** Match team capability to the ambiguity and complexity of Routing while developing existing engineers.
- **Protext System-Health Investment.** Create enough capacity to fix recurring problems instead of continually absorbing their operational consequences.

Threats

- **Continued System Degradation.** Feature and support pressure can continue crowding out work needed to improve reliability and data integrity.
- **Key-Person Attrition or Burnout.** Concentrated knowledge makes losing a key engineer disproportionately damaging.
- **False Capacity from Added Headcount.** Adding engineers without sufficient context can initially increase the burden on existing SMEs rather than relieve it.
- **Q4 Execution Pressure.** Near-term commitments can crowd out the stabilization work necessary to improve future delivery.
- **Scaling Unreliable Workflows.** Automation and self-service can amplify problems when the underlying process is not yet trustworthy.

Routing Stabilization Priorities

Stabilize the Operating Model

Goal: Make work visible, deliberate and executable

- Establish clearer intake and prioritization
- Turn refinement into actual work preparation
- Make capacity and displacement explicit
- Reduce unnecessary WIP and context switching
- Create clearer boundaries around support

Expected Results: The team knows what it is committed to, why it matters and what moves when something new becomes urgent

Build Team Ownership

Goal: Make Routing less dependent on individual heroes

- Create repeatable onboarding
- Pair and record critical system work
- Establish secondary owners
- Improve current-state documentation and runbooks
- Develop existing engineers while adding the right senior capability

Expected Results: Critical workflows can be understood and safely owned by multiple engineers instead of depending on one person.

Create Room to Fix the System

Goal: Reduce the work that keeps making Routing reactive

- Connect recurring support to root causes
- Protect engineering capacity for system health
- Harden workflows before automating them
- Reduce recurring manual interventions
- Make Product/Engineering tradeoffs explicit when system work competes with customer asks

Expected Results: Support demand begins to decline because the underlying causes are being addressed rather than repeatedly serviced.

Notes

- Stabilization will give us better information about team boundaries, ownership and zone design. I do not think three weeks is enough context to recommend a broader reorganization.
- Note that the concentration risk in this document is localized to Routing. I know there is concern around Vince, but after multiple discussions at different levels I have confidence that within the zone the concentration risk is not the same level of concern.

What a Healthier Routing Team Looks Like

Predictable Execution

Routing can clearly explain what it is committed to, what is at risk and what gets displaced when priorities change

Distributed Ownership

Important systems and workflows have multiple engineers capable of understanding, operating and changing them safely.

Controlled Support

Support enters through a clear path, is prioritized against other work and produces root-cause investment when patterns emerge.

Better Product/Engineering Discovery

Teams enter execution with a shared understanding of the problem, expected outcome, major dependencies and remaining unknowns.

Improved System Health

Engineering has enough protected capacity to reduce recurring operational work instead of continually absorbing it.

The goal is not to make Vince less important. It is to make his knowledge, and the knowledge of other experienced engineers across the zone, create leverage rather than dependency.

What I need from Leadership

Support explicit prioritization tradeoffs, protect necessary system-health investments and give us flexibility to align senior engineering capability with the complexity of the work.